

# Fewer notices, or fewer illegalities?

A public claim, tested against twenty years of annual reports

## THE CLAIM

***“We had times when we issued over 1,000 enforcement notices per year.”***

Johann Buttigieg, Planning Authority CEO, The Malta Independent, 7 September 2025

Now around 200, which he attributed to there being fewer illegalities.

The Authority's own 2024 report credits the fall to persuading contraveners first.

## VERDICT

# MISLEADING

*Accurate figures,  
incomplete explanation.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY  
SUPPORTED

NOT  
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

## MAIN RESULTS

### 1,033

Then: over 1,000 a year

Average notices a year 2001–2009 (MEPA). The figure is right.

### 187

Now: around 200

Average 2020–2024 (Planning Authority). Also right: notices fell 82%.

### –11%

Complaints barely fell

2,701 complaints in 2009, 2,411 in 2024; 3,313 in 2020.

### ~1,200

Still confirmed illegal

About half of 2024 complaints were confirmed as illegal development.

### 521

Settled by legalising

In 2024 more cases ended in a sanctioning application than any other way; 162 got a notice.

## FAIR TO SAY

The chief executive also said the Authority has struggled with enforcement. Persuading owners first is a recognised approach. This check is about what fewer notices can show.

## WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ Complaints and outcomes for 2012–2018.

☐ Any survey showing illegal building has fallen.

☐ How many cases end in a sanctioning permit.

☐ The yearly source of 1,500 direct actions.